

ECC006 Homework Assignment #5

1. Which of the following are the three most common methods for organizing websites?
 - a. horizontal, vertical, and diagonal
 - b. hierarchical, linear, and random
 - c. accessible, readable, and maintainable
 - d. none of the above
2. Which of the following are the four principles of the Web Content Accessibility Guidelines?
 - a. repetition, contrast, proximity, and alignment
 - b. perceivable, operable, understandable, and robust
 - c. accessible, readable, maintainable, and reliable
 - d. hierarchical, linear, random, and sequential
3. Which of the following are influenced by the intended or target audience of a site?
 - a. The amount of color used on the site
 - b. The font size and styles used on the site
 - c. The overall look and feel of the site
 - d. All of the above
4. Which of the following recommended design practices apply to a web site that uses images for its main site navigation?
 - a. Provide alternative text for the images.
 - b. Place text links at the bottom of the page.
 - c. Both a and b.
 - d. No special considerations are needed.
5. Which of the following is a color scheme that consists of two colors that are opposite each other on the color wheel?
 - a. analogous
 - b. complementary
 - c. split complementary
 - d. contrasting
6. Choose two sites that are similar in nature or have a similar target audience, such as the following:
 - Amazon.com (<http://www.amazon.com>) and Alibaba.com (<https://www.alibaba.com/>)
 - CNN(<http://www.cnn.com>) and MSNBC(<http://www.msnbc.com>)

Describe how the two sites you chose to review exhibit the design principles of repetition, contrast, proximity, and alignment.

1. Repetition

Repetition creates consistency and helps users predict how a site works. Amazon: Amazon relies heavily on repetition in its product grids. Every search result displays the same recurring format: image, title, rating, price and Prime shipping availability on the left (or top). Navigation menus remain consistently at the top of every page. The "Add to Cart" and "Buy Now" buttons are consistently the same shape and color across millions of pages

Alibaba: Alibaba also uses recurring grid layouts for search results, but the recurring elements highlight B2B needs. Each product card consistently lists the "Minimum Order Quantity" (MOQ) and "Years of Suppliers" repeating this specific data structure to allow buyers to easily browse and compare different manufacturers

2. Contrast

Contrast draws the user's eye to the most important elements on the page

Amazon: Amazon uses a clean, white background to create high contrast with its dark text. The most significant use of contrast is in its call-to-action (CTA) buttons. The yellow "Add to Cart" and orange "Buy Now" buttons create a sharp contrast against the rest of the page instantly showing the user what they need to do to complete the purchase

Alibaba: Alibaba uses its brand color (a vibrant orange) to create contrast. Like Amazon, primary action buttons such as "Contact Supplier" or "Start Order" are bright orange against a white background. This sharp contrast directs the user's eye directly to the point of conversion

3. Proximity

Proximity allows the brain to process related elements as a single unit by grouping them together

Amazon: Amazon heavily utilizes proximity on its product pages. Product titles, prices, reviews and variations (such as size or color) are grouped close together. Amazon also cleverly uses proximity in its "Frequently Bought Together" sections grouping three different products closely together to encourage increased sales

Alibaba: Alibaba groups product pricing tiers close together (e.g "\$5.00 for 1-99 units" "\$4.50 for 100-499 units"). By placing these tiers close together buyers instantly understand how scaling their orders affects the price. Supplier credentials (response time, location, verified status) are also grouped in a single "company profile" box

4. Alignment

Alignment creates a sharp and organized look allowing the eye to scan the page naturally

Amazon: Amazon uses a strict grid alignment. Search results are perfectly aligned horizontally and vertically. Text in product descriptions is left-aligned this is the most natural alignment for Western readers to quickly scan. The large search bar is centered at the top, anchoring the entire site

Alibaba: Alibaba also uses a similar grid-based alignment. On the homepage, categories are aligned in a strict left column, while promotional banners and product grids are right-aligned. This structural alignment prevents large amounts of information from appearing chaotic

5. The Five-Click Rule

The five-click rule suggests that a user should be able to find what they want and reach their goal in five or fewer clicks

Amazon (B2C Focused): Amazon is king in reducing click counts. Standard Path: Search (1) > Click Product (2) > Add to Cart (3) > Proceed to Checkout (4) > Place Order (5). Optimized Path: With the patented "Order in 1 Click" feature enabled, the user can search (1), click on a product (2) and click "Buy Now in 1 Click" (3). Amazon significantly increases conversion rates by completing the purchase in just 3 clicks

Alibaba (B2B Focused): On Alibaba, the purchase process usually involves bargaining rather than a simple cart checkout, but the user interface is still designed to get the process started quickly. Path: Search (1) > Click on Product (2) > Click on "Contact Supplier" (3) > Write a message and click Send (4). While finalizing a large wholesale deal can take days of messaging, initiating the transaction easily meets the 5-click rule. The payment process for "Ready to Ship" retail products mirrors Amazon's 4-5 click cart process

CNN and MSNBC comparison

1. Repetition

Repetition involves using the same or similar elements throughout the design to create consistency, unity, and predictability for the user

CNN: CNN uses extensive repetition in its typography and layout structures. On the homepage, the format of a news story is consistently repeated: a thumbnail followed by a bold headline and a short summary or related links below. The iconic "CNN Red" is used repeatedly in breaking news banners, live update points and section headings, familiarizing the user with this color and associating it with urgent or important information

MSNBC: Because MSNBC places great emphasis on its television programming, it repeats specific visual motifs associated with its programs. The layout relies on repeating "cards" (blocks) containing a video thumbnail a play button icon in the center and a headline. This repeated module allows the user to instantly understand which articles are text-based and which are video clips

2. Contrast

Contrast is used to highlight differences between elements, to make the most important information stand out, and to guide the user's eye

CNN: CNN is a master of high-contrast design. The site predominantly uses a clean, white background and dark, almost black text for optimal readability. However the most striking use of contrast is in the "Breaking News" headlines. When there is important news, CNN uses a striking, bright red headline with bold white text at the top of the page. This extreme contrast ensures that the eye is immediately drawn to the most critical information above all else

MSNBC: MSNBC uses contrast to highlight its media. The site often uses a striking white background, which makes dark, colorful, high-resolution video thumbnails pop off the page. Additionally they use contrasting font weights very heavy bold fonts for main headlines compared to lighter, thinner fonts for subheadings or author names creating a clear visual hierarchy

3. Proximity

Proximity allows the user's brain to process related elements as a single, integrated unit rather than as separate pieces of information by grouping them together

CNN: CNN uses proximity to create context. A key headline is often placed right next to bulleted links related to the same ongoing story. By grouping them closely together, the user understands that they belong to the same narrative. Additionally the author's name and timestamps are placed directly below the headline to which they

belong

MSNBC: MSNBC frequently uses proximity to group content around specific television personalities or programs (e.g Rachel Maddow or Morning Joe). The host's photo, the program's logo and a list of recent video clips are tightly bound together in a single segment. This proximity signals to the viewer that all these elements are part of that particular program's brand

4. Alignment

Alignment prevents a page from looking like a chaotic jumble of text and images by creating order and structure. It creates an invisible line that the eye can follow

CNN: CNN uses a rigid multi-column grid layout (typically three columns on a desktop). Almost all text from the main navigation links at the top to the smallest article headings is left-aligned. This is quite deliberate as left-aligned text is the easiest and most natural way for Western audiences to quickly read. The columns act like invisible vertical lines, organizing the large amount of news in an orderly manner

MSNBC: MSNBC also relies on a strong grid system but generally uses wider more extensive columns to accommodate large video players. They use strong horizontal alignment in the top navigation and category menus. Similar to CNN their text is left-aligned but they often center the play buttons within the video thumbnails creating a focal point right in the middle of the image block